SEPTEMBER 2025, NO 1

US Army Drone Team



Military International Drone Racing Tournament

The US Army Drone Team competed at the Military International Drone Racing Tournament (MIDRT) hosted at the Royal Military Academy Sandhurst (UK). Our mission was to represent the US Army, strengthen relationships with international partners, and advance FPV drone tactics, technology, and training methods.

Lessons Learned

by CPT JACOB E BICKUS

This year's competition featured 14 teams from across the globe: Australia (two teams) New Zealand (two teams) United Kingdom – Army, Navy, Royal Air Force, and Marines US Army and US Naval Academy (two teams) Germany-Belgium combined team and the Philippines.

Personnel: Arriving early allowed time for rest, acclimatization, and equipment preparation. The ideal team consists of 4 FPV operators and 1 OIC/Liaison. Teams with fewer operators were at a disadvantage in scoring.

Training: Racing and tactical drone flying are not synonymous. Racing demands split-second decision making and precision under stress. Two views emerged: racing develops battlefield-ready operators quickly, or tactical and racing training must remain separate to develop exceptional skill.

Equipment: The team relied on personal gear, while others had sponsor-provided racing drones. Tactical drones are too heavy and less maneuverable for racing. Future teams need multiple spare racing drones, extra arms, flight computers, and electronic speed controllers.



SGT Bradley and CPT Johnson prepare their drones at the race starting point.

Looking Forward

The lessons learned at Sandhurst provide a clear roadmap for the US Army Drone Team: Build a dedicated racing kit separate from tactical drones. Expand training pipeline to integrate both tactical and racing skill sets. Seek sponsorship opportunities or formal equipment support. Strengthen international partnerships as we prepare for Sydney 2026.



SSG Smith overlooks as SGT Bradley repairs FPV drone with help from a Belgium Officer.

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